

‘They need somebody to make decisions for them, because they can’t make them for themselves.’

— CATALINA HINOJOSA, outreach worker



A HOMELESS MAN, wrapped in a bedcover, walks by two others near an alley in Westlake that’s known for fentanyl use.

Photographs by GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

Too little help for so much pain

STEVE LOPEZ



He was bent at the waist, wobbly and shoeless on grimy pavement at the end of an alley where fires smolder, drug users gather day and night, and death lurks.

Slowly, he made his way across the parking lot behind the Yoshinoya restaurant at Wilshire Boulevard and Alvarado Street. It was not a normal gait, but in MacArthur Park, you see it every day.

The head hangs low. The eyes sink. Fentanyl, over time, attacks muscle and spine, cuts people in half, twists them in knots, and buries them. In 2022, 1,910 fentanyl overdose deaths were recorded in Los Angeles County.

When the man paused in a parking lot, I approached. His face was scarred by a shotgun pattern of blood-red scabs and ulcers. This too is a common sight, and a symptom of fentanyl laced with the veterinary tranquilizer xylazine.

He said that his name is Aaron and that he came to L.A. two years ago from Louisiana. He couldn’t remember what had happened to his shoes. One foot was bare, the other was sheathed in a dirty sock. He told me that when he uses fentanyl, “it’s kind of like, you just start

[See Lopez, A5]



“I CAN’T deal with life sober,” said Aaron, 31, near MacArthur Park. He said he suffers from bipolar disorder.

NEWSOM SOUNDS ALARM AGAINST BIRD FLU

Governor declares emergency as virus spreads and Louisiana reports a serious case.

By SUSANNE RUST

Gov. Gavin Newsom declared a state of emergency Wednesday as the H5N1 bird flu virus moved from the Central Valley to Southern California dairy herds, while federal officials confirmed the first U.S. case of severe illness in a hospitalized Louisiana patient — a concerning development as the virus continues to spread throughout the nation via migrating birds.

The declaration by Newsom will allow for a more streamlined approach among state and local agencies to tackle the virus, providing “flexibility around staffing, contracting, and other rules to support California’s evolving response,” according to a statement.

“Building on California’s testing and monitoring system — the largest in the nation — we are committed to further protecting public health, supporting our agriculture industry, and ensuring that Californians have access to accurate, up-to-date information,” Newsom said in the statement. “While the risk to the public remains low, we will continue to take all necessary steps to prevent the spread of this virus.”

According to the U.S. Department of Agriculture, 645 dairy herds in California have reportedly been infected with the H5N1 virus since August. Nationwide, the number is 865 and stretches back to March,

[See Bird flu, A10]



BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

PRO-TRUMP STUDENTS at Beverly Hills High School held two days of what the district termed “spirited demonstrations” to celebrate the election results.

Trump rallies roil school

Victory celebrations at Beverly Hills High escalate tensions, leave Black students and teacher shaken

By NOAH GOLDBERG

A high-ranking administrator in the Beverly Hills Unified School District had an urgent, confidential message for the school board.

It was Oct. 27, just over a week before the presidential election, and tensions at Beverly Hills High School between Persian Jewish stu-

dents and Black students were quickly escalating, wrote Laura Collins-Williams, an assistant superintendent for student services in the district. The school year had already seen a flurry of confrontations and fights and even a video that circulated of a student uttering a racial slur, she wrote.

“We must act urgently to

prevent further violence,” Collins-Williams wrote. “Without immediate intervention, I fear violence will prevail.”

The message was ominous, but the messenger had a complicated history. For nine months, Collins-Williams had been embroiled in her own battle, accusing the district in a law-

[See Tensions, A10]

103 victims of ‘rape club’ prison to get \$116 million

By RICHARD WINTON

In a staggering settlement, the federal government will pay \$116 million to more than 100 women who said they were sexually abused by employees at a now-shuttered federal prison in Dublin, Calif., that was dubbed the “rape club.”

The settlement is the largest amount ever paid by

the federal government for misconduct in federal prisons. The women will receive an average of about \$1.1 million each to settle litigation against the Bureau of Prisons over their mistreatment at the Federal Correctional Institution Dublin in the San Francisco Bay Area.

The development is the latest twist in a years-long scandal surrounding the facility. Since an FBI investi-

gation was launched and resulted in arrests in 2021, eight FCI Dublin employees have been charged with sexually abusing inmates.

Five have pleaded guilty, and juries have convicted two, including former Warden Ray Garcia. The Bureau of Prisons in April temporarily closed the prison because it was so plagued by sexual abuse that it was known as

[See Prison, A5]

X Games plans to exit Southland

Summer version of the extreme sports competition will move to Sacramento. CALIFORNIA, B1

A caveat as Fed again cuts rates

Central bank makes a trim but dials back forecast for future reductions. BUSINESS, A6

Weather

Mostly sunny, warm. L.A. Basin: 79/50. B6

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FRANK AUGSTEIN Associated Press

TROUBLE FOR TRUDEAU

Canadian leader Justin Trudeau, right, with then-President Trump in 2019, has lost popularity and now faces calls to step down. WORLD, A3



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